India's Press Freedom and the Role of the Press Council of India

The Press Council of India (PCI) is an important body that looks after the freedom and fairness of the press. It was first set up in 1966 and now works under the Press Council Act, 1978. The Council has 28 members, including a Chairman (usually a retired Supreme Court judge), journalists, editors, publishers, and some nominated members. Its term is for three years.

Roles of PCI

- Guardian of Press Freedom – Protects newspapers and journalists from unfair control by government or business groups.
- Regulator – Makes rules of ethics and good conduct for journalists.
- Quasi-Judicial Authority – Works like a civil court to hear complaints.
- Advisory Body – Gives suggestions to the government on media matters.
- Balancing Freedom and Duty – Ensures press freedom is not misused against public interest.

Responsibilities of PCI

- Inquiry into Complaints – Checks cases of false or unfair reporting.

- Promoting High Standards – Encourages truth, fairness, and accuracy in news.
- Disciplinary Action – Can warn or censure newspapers or journalists.
- Awareness – Educates press and people about ethical journalism.
- Reports & Research – Publishes studies on press and media freedom.

Why PCI is Useful

- Protects democracy by keeping the press free and fair.
- Stops misuse like fake news and sensational reporting.
- Gives a platform for journalists to raise their problems.
- Advises the government without being under political control.
- Builds trust between people and the media.

Current Issue

At present, the PCI is facing problems because the 14th Council ended in October 2024, but the 15th Council has not been formed yet. This delay has made the PCI almost defunct, leaving more than 400 cases pending. The Mumbai Press Club and other journalist bodies have gone to the Delhi High Court asking for immediate reconstitution. The Court has issued notices to the government and PCI, and the matter will be heard again in July 2025.

Meanwhile, India's ranking in the World Press Freedom Index 2025 has slipped to 161 out of 180 countries, showing a big fall from 150 in 2022. Reporters Without Borders (RSF) says this is because of rising restrictions, arrests of journalists, and censorship. This shows how urgent it is to have a strong and active PCI.

Conclusion

The Press Council of India is like a watchdog of the press. Without it, journalists and newspapers become more vulnerable. To protect democracy and the people's right to know the truth, the PCI must be reconstituted quickly and work without delay.

Source:

- https://firstne.in/uncategorized/indias-press-freedom-ranking-slips-amid-delay-in-reconstituting-press-council-of-india/3807/
- https://universalinstitutions.com/press-council-of-india-pci-ensuring-press-freedom-and-ethics/